

in the software field to draft contracts such as the Master Services Agreement, etc, to clearly demarcate who owns the intellectual property. All the work specifically developed for a client remains its IP. The remaining IP that comes from OSS is considered 'background IP' with no exclusive rights provided to the client, allowing those pieces, libraries, etc, to be used in multiple situations for different clients and for the benefit of the OSS community, especially developers.

For a client, there is a strong business case for adopting OSS because of the reduced CAPEX involved, especially with reliable products that come with robust source code and documentation.

So are most of Bizosys' customers adopting open source software along with proprietary applications, or are they replacing the later completely? "In the Big Data space, there are new robust solutions such as SAP HANA that have made inroads into the in-memory solutions domain to deal with the volume, velocity, variety of data that firms need to deal with. These are seen as complementary solutions to existing, monolithic systems that are very expensive to scale, and even then do not match HANA's scale or performance. HSearch is a disk-based solution and clearly can be an alternative. We don't see customers replacing their existing core systems, ERP solutions, etc, entirely, but adding OSS solutions to complement their existing IT investments. Sure, there are smaller, niche systems that may be replaced entirely, such as log management software where scale is a huge challenge; and large historical data stores where alerting is critical, especially as the external environment changes in terms of competition or regulations. OSS adoption is likely to continue on a complementary basis in most cases, and for specific niche situations, might be replacing the proprietary software used earlier," says Dhulipala.

The bottlenecks in adopting FOSS

Dhulipala has a lot to say about the challenges faced by firms that sell open source solutions. While elaborating on the toughest hurdle his team has faced so far, he says, "Evangelising and spreading the word, followed by building a solid, active community of users, are the challenges. Currently, there is no one platform to find and enrol evangelists or developers—one has to depend on blogs. Besides, a majority of OSS is often created by smaller teams with little or no funding, except for the rare Cloudera or Hortonworks, the developers of which managed to raise millions for their model or distribution of Hadoop. Second, it's a challenge to find sharp developers who share your vision of the OSS product, its roadmap and are willing to become 'committers'. The single largest challenge in building a vibrant OSS community is finding the evangelists and committers."

And what does he feel is the biggest hurdle in the adoption of open source solutions at the enterprise

level? Dhulipala replies, "The single biggest hurdle is often support, followed by the solution's ease of use. Developers often are required to either think differently or master new skills when it comes to several OSS products, especially in the NoSQL space. Next, the credibility of the OSS solution comes into play. A good number of successful deployments in the particular industry that the prospective client belongs to, also helps in adoption. These challenges become harder in highly regulated industries such as finance and insurance, where there might be viable OSS alternatives hypothetically that could be stitched together to form a core banking solution, for instance, but lack of deployments prevents adoption. On the other hand, cost-sensitive industries in highly competitive segments would gladly look for an OSS solution for certain functions."

Interaction with the community and the days ahead

Regarding Bizosys' involvement with the open source community at the global level, Dhulipala shares, "There are two ways we have engaged with the OSS community — sharing our work via popular forums such as Microsoft Teched, Yahoo Hadoop Summit, Hasgeek Fifth Elephant, and several of the emerging local meet-ups that are less formal in nature. The source code for HSearch is itself available via a dedicated website www.hadoopsearch.net maintained currently by Bizosys, and also on Github and Sourceforge."

So what are the innovative solutions that Bizosys' is working on at present? "Bizosys is a Big Data advanced analytics company that sees its growth coming from the constant, rapid increase in data volumes, both structured and unstructured. Today, user generated content and machine log data are primary contributors to the high volumes, e.g., social feeds and metadata on a huge number of monitored events. Tomorrow, this is likely to grow even more with the IoT or Internet of Things scenario. Against this backdrop, Bizosys sees its solutions' ability to deal with the twin demands of scale and performance as its key strength, and its roadmap is based on strengthening offerings that fundamentally address this challenge. We will address the packaging of these solutions, from a business standpoint, whether it is real-time predictive analytics on streaming data or a cost-effective and smarter data store to manage petabytes of data and more. As businesses prepare to deal with data-driven challenges in terms of analytics, operations, customer experience or plain growth and differentiation, Bizosys expects to align its business and industry-specific solutions more finely to these challenges. All along, we expect OSS to be core to our business strategy," concludes Dhulipala. 

By Priyanka Sarkar

The author is a member of the editorial team. She loves to weave in and out the little nuances of life and scribble her thoughts and experiences in her personal blog.